

from well-off families. Their parents leave early for work, and food cooked in the morning often lasts the whole day. But players need fresh food and proper nutrition. So we provide meals, including non-vegetarian food at least three times a week," said Harikrishnan.

He pauses to show a set of used injection needles he once took from a boy, a talented left-footed player who had slipped into addiction.

"I got him admitted to Guru Nanak College through the sports quota, but he drifted away. At one point, I had to involve the police," he recalled.

For Harikrishnan, football is not just about producing elite players. It is about keeping doors open: to education, to employment and, at times, simply to a better path.

### A mother's sacrifice

The journey of a 14-year-old from Sirukalathur offers a glimpse into what that path can demand.

Chennaiyin FC U-13, FC Madras U-13 and U-15, district titles, CM Trophy representation, AIFF FIFA Talent Academy selection, and individual awards, the list is already long for Dharanivendhan (pic below).

At home, it is held together by his mother, Kalaimani.

"We come from a village, and I do not know many bus routes because I did not complete my schooling. It is my son who has shown me places. I have travelled with him for camps and trials," she said.

"With a daily income of around Rs. 300, we spend nearly half on him. The rest goes towards food and household expenses."

Her routine once began at 2 a.m.

To get her son to training in the city, she would travel to Poonamallee and then take another bus to the ground, wait outside for two hours, and return home by noon, day after day, for a year.

Dharanivendhan would then attend school for half a day.

Today, he is back training at Sirukalathur, with a return to FC Madras on the horizon.

In a village where journeys once rarely extended beyond its borders, they now begin before sunrise, on narrow roads, in crowded buses, and on a patch of ground marked by flags.

For some, it leads to a team sheet.

For others, to a college seat.

For all of them, it offers a way forward.

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